pranks—harmless graffiti on mosques, an occasional tree set ablaze by mischievous teenagers. Official statistics from the United Nations paint a somewhat more serious picture. Some 50 people were injured and more than 2,500 trees damaged in 2011 alone. (About half of Palestine's farmland is planted with olive trees, and the industry supports some 80,000 families.)

Yitzhar has perhaps the most outsized reputation. In that particular year, it earned the distinction of carrying out more attacks than any other settlement: seventy in all, one-sixth of the year's total, despite having fewer than 2,000 residents.[1] Most of the violence is directed at Palestinians; their homes, churches and mosques; and their olive groves.

In an indication of the changing times, however, the settlers are also turning their ire on the Israeli army that protects them. This happened in Yitzhar in April 2014, after the border police (a paramilitary force which operates mostly in the occupied territories) demolished five houses that had been built without the proper permits. They were confronted by hundreds of angry residents, throwing stones and burning tires to block the streets. Six officers were injured. The settlers later trashed the army post inside the settlement, even slashing the tires on a colonel's jeep. It was the second time his vehicle had been vandalized there in three months.

The authorities responded by shuttering one of Israel's most notorious *yeshivot*, or Jewish religious schools, called *Od Yosef Chai* ("Joseph Still Lives"). It had originally been located inside Joseph's Tomb, a religious site in the Palestinian-controlled outskirts of Nablus, but it was relocated to Yitzhar after the outbreak of the second intifada. Yitzhak Shapira, formerly one of its top rabbis, penned an infamous tract in 2009 called *Torat HaMelech* ("The King's Torah"), which argued that Jews were permitted to kill non-Jews who threatened them, even children. "It is reasonable to harm children if it is clear that they will grow up to harm us," he wrote.

The Israeli army said the yeshiva had become a "hub" for launching attacks on the surrounding communities. "The reason [for the closure] is twofold, first because of the rising violence that is originating from the area of the yeshiva", said Lt Col Peter Lerner, an army spokesman. "And secondly, because of the recent violence there directed at the army. This vandalism is a major concern for us."

Within Yitzhar, all of this became the subject of an unexpected debate. Residents decided to hold an unofficial referendum on whether stone-throwing and other actions against the army were a valid response to future